C Y P H

şifr *(n., arabic)* — zero; the void; the origin of mathematics.

cipher *(n., cryptography)* — a code; a way of encoding meaning.

cypher *(n., music)* — a circle of voices in sequence.

cyph *(n.)* — the new underground for ideas.

founders

jalen daniels

philosopher · technologist · strategist



alma mater
harvard

previous work
ex-mckinsey

startup growth	
institution building	
public intellectual	
inbox 0	
classical ballet	

researching
transhumanism · nietzsche · urban agriculture

bryan cash

computer scientist · sports savant · optimizer



alma mater
syracuse

previous work
ex-washington post

enterprise apps	
design engineering	
big data	
bowling	
chess	

researching
technofeudalism · neuroathletics · molecular gastronomy

advisory board



bakari kitwana
ex-eic of the source magazine

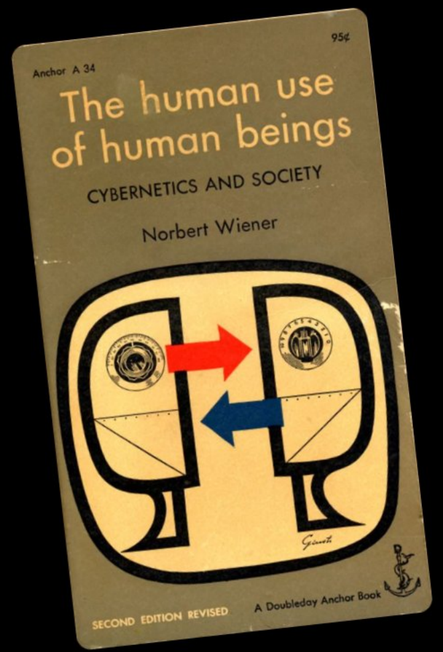


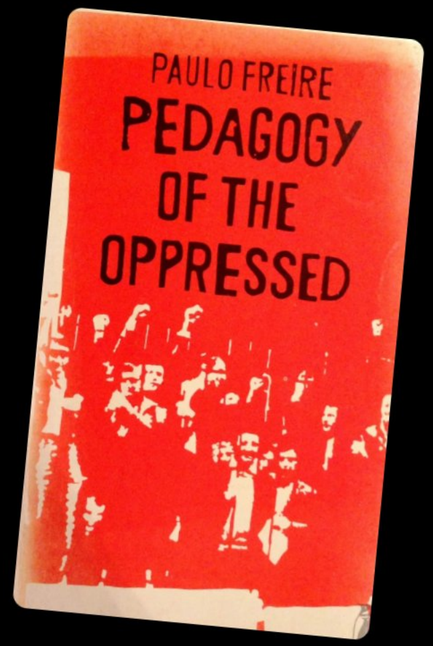
caitlin begg
ceo of authentic social and return to analog podcast

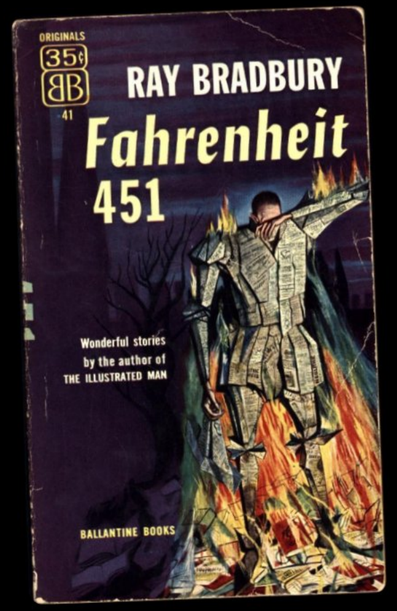


calvary rogers
ex-google, founder of seneca labs

we're in an epistemic crisis.







ai → cognitive resignation

"your brain on chatgpt: accumulation of cognitive debt"

mit media lab

'veritas' is threatened

"college professors say their academic freedom is in decline"

THE CHRONICLE OF HIGHER EDUCATION

monopolized knowledge

"anthropic destroyed millions of rare books to train their models"

wp

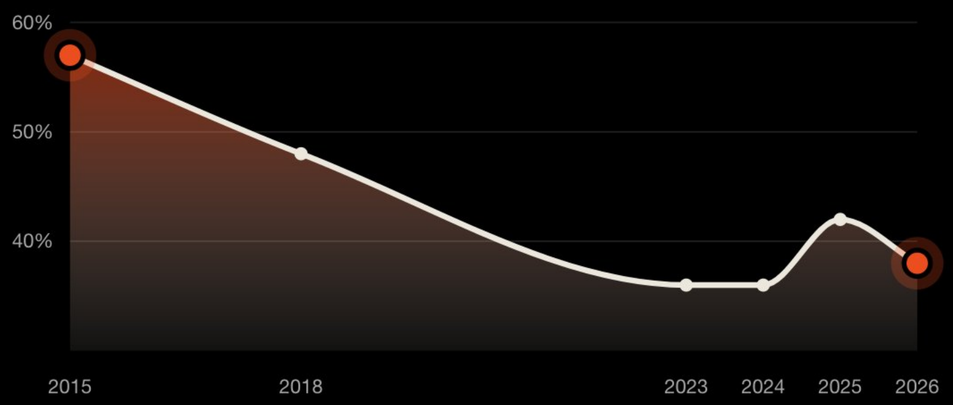
universities were once built for world changing ideas. now they block them.

what we heard across **450+** expert interviews.

public trust in higher ed

57% → **38%**

2015 2026



01 the most treasured sources are buried.

“The Books of College Libraries Are Turning Into Wallpaper”

A

02 the boldest ideas are punished.

“Texas A&M professor barred from teaching Plato’s Symposium”

IHE Inside Higher Ed

03 the best research never leaves campus.

“most scholars want to share their work with the public, but get no support to do it”

WISCONSIN UNIVERSITY OF WISCONSIN–MADISON 6,200 FACULTY

the answers to our most pressing problems are collecting dust.

GALLUP Lumina FOUNDATION

and as ai fills the internet, people are searching harder for human wisdom.

type of person	size benchmark	fragmented across
seekers people who are not satisfied with the first answer.	**1.5B+** monthly unique devices W	
sparrers people who want to test ideas with real people.	**550M+** monthly active users	
authorities people with domain authority who distribute their ideas.	**30M+** paid memberships	

no single home for ideas

key insights

76% — **people crave verified, human-made material.**
need to know if what they read is human-made
ai labs scanned millions of pre-ai books to train on wp

2.5M+ — **people want to unlock their inner scholar.**
follow 2-hour lectures on plato and history SSENSE
the ai age will reward people who choose mental effort A

+31% — **people want to think together, not in isolation.**
growth in book club and “salon” events NBC NEWS

47% — **people crave masters, not influencers.**
call influencers a top source of misinformation
bookish creators lead the anti-slop wave VOGUE

but every epistemic crisis always had an underground.



the agora

athens, 500 bc

where free thought had a home before the academy existed.



the salon

paris, 1700s

where conversations that built the enlightenment happened in living rooms.



harlem renaissance

new york, 1920s

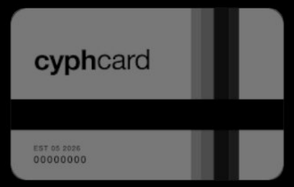
where Black intellectuals made space for possibility in the midst of danger.

cyph is the first underground for human wisdom in the digital age.



see trailer here

user journey





01

underground

where you become intellectually dangerous.

uncover a living world of buried artifacts, rare books, and suppressed ideas — all human made.*







publish or explore routes to intellectual destinations.

the nietzsche route

25 stops

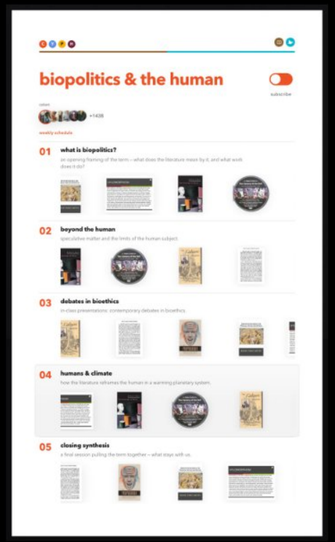
the athlete as activist

21 stops

silence as composition

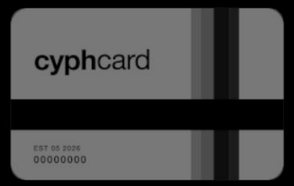
11 stops

teach a cohort learning sesh based on syllabi you design.



*seeded from open source, institutional, and personal collections.

user journey









02

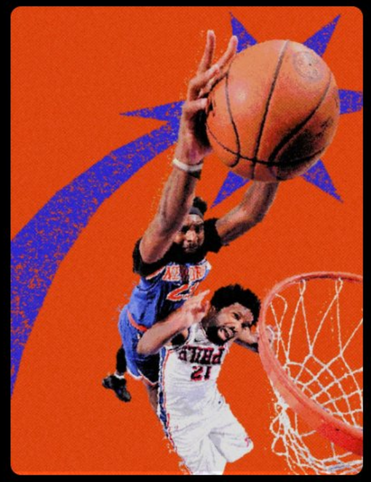
the cyph

where ideas get tested in real time.

spark with thinkers around the world in real time. go deeper in office hours with underground scholars.

live

topics sourced from API's & real-time listening.



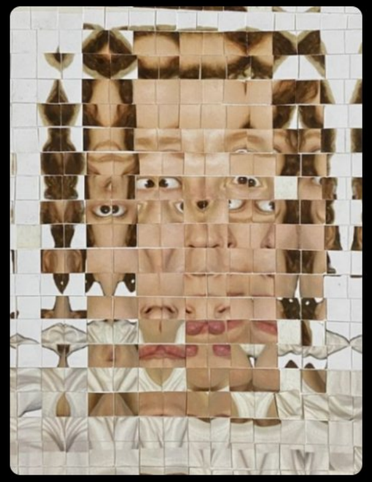
knicks championship



hosted by chris robinson

conceptual

ideas surfaced from pulses in deep research.

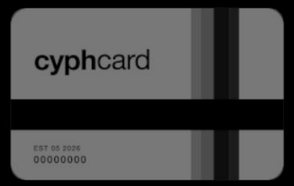


is the soul actually cartesian?



hosted by iain mcgilchrist

user journey









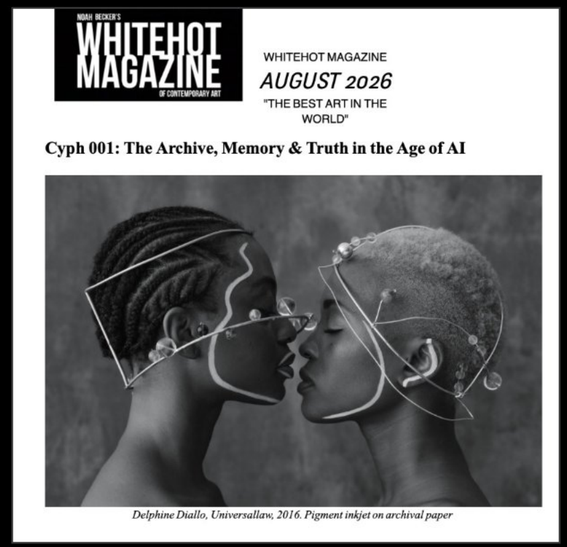
03

irl

close the laptop and enter our world of IRL cyphs: lectures, office hours, supper clubs, & debates. the research from the room is archived in our partner libraries.

our last cyph...





in the room

GUGGENHEIM · OpenAI · GQ · ESSENCE · Google · STUDIO MUSEUM IN HARLEM · HBO · SQUARESPACE · DEPT · CODE AND THEORY · ISE-DA · RÉSONNER · NYC Public Schools · SUPERPOSITION · THE ROOT

10+ residential libraries in nyc where cyph members can check out books.

user journey







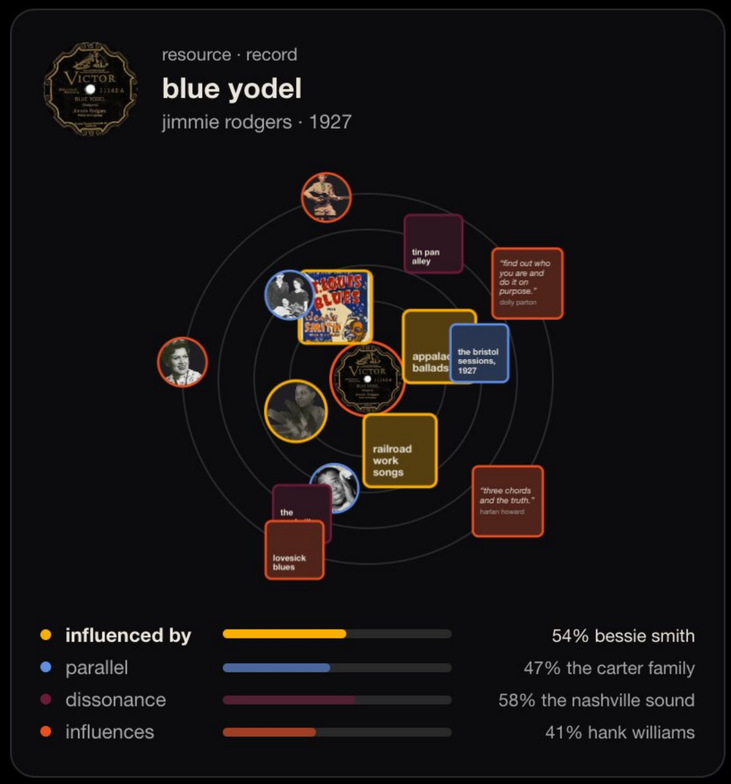


04

how it all maps together

everything on cyph has its own dna. map the influence, and intersections of your ideas over time with the cyphcard.





traction.

150+

office hour leads

e.g., ex-professors, street scholars, domain masters



what cyph unlocks for them

revenue, authority, expanded audience

what they unlock for cyph

credibility, built-in audiences

500+

seeded partners

e.g., open-source archives, museums, libraries, universities

JSTOR · Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture, The New York Public Library · Sage · Internet Archive · arXiv · Studio Museum Harlem · Anthology Film Archives · Dust to Digital · FIFA Museum

what cyph unlocks for them

foot traffic, citations, conversions

what they unlock for cyph

verified sources, institutional trust

11K+

artifacts from personal collections

e.g., estates, family archives



what cyph unlocks for them

discovery, legacy, wealth generation

what they unlock for cyph

exclusive inventory, a moat AI can't copy

how we make money.

cyph.edu

universities pay to turn their libraries into a living underground, shared with the peer schools they choose.

think *jstor meets early facebook*

unlock *scholarship for the everyday citizen, and campuses thinking out loud together again.*

cyphcard+

members pay annually for unlimited cohorts and rare perks, like residential libraries.

think *the met annual membership meets unlimited masterclass*

unlock *membership in an underground intelligentsia, that rewards you for being curious*



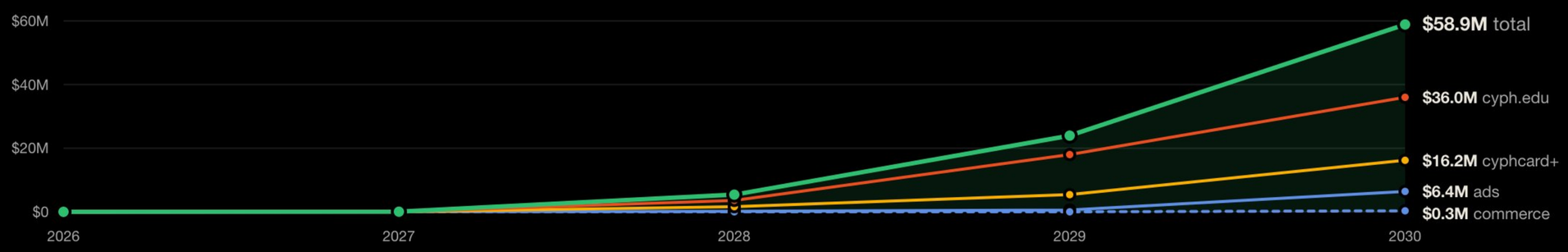
ads + commerce

partners pay for placements across cyph city, and we take a cut of each conversion.

think *pinterest's discovery, wirecutter's economics.*

unlock *integrated ads endorsed by the first digital underground*



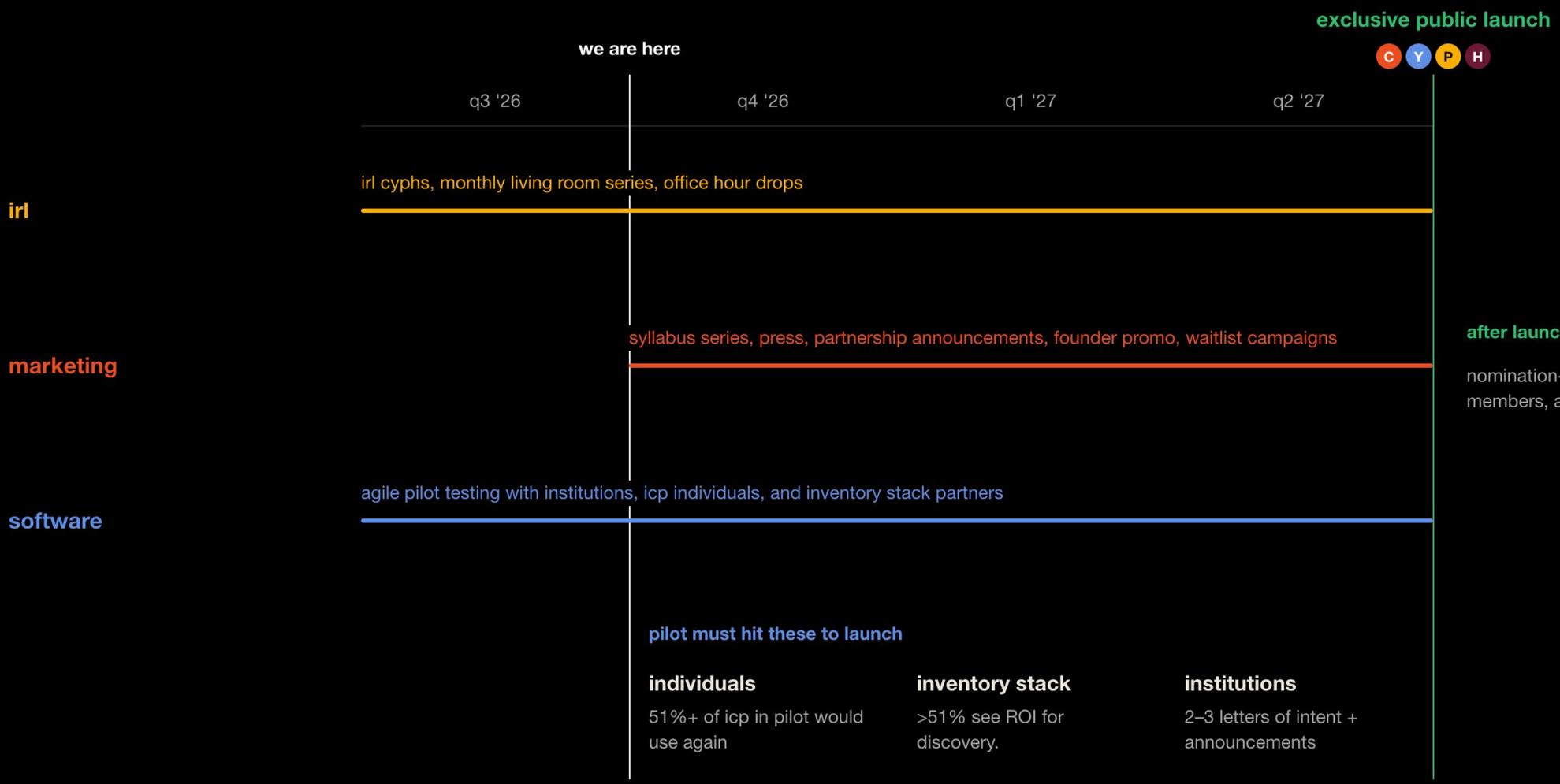


cyph scales to **~$59M revenue by 2030** at **~73.4% gross margins**...while keeping wisdom free for every user.

projections available upon request.

gtm.

build irl community while testing with icp, launch by invitation.



after launch

nomination-only*: members nominate members, and the waitlist grows

pilot must hit these to launch

individuals

51%+ of icp in pilot would use again

inventory stack

>51% see ROI for discovery.

institutions

2–3 letters of intent + announcements

**while nomination-only, clubhouse grew from 600k registered users (dec 2020) to 10m weekly active users (feb 2021) and a $4b valuation.*

what real people have said.

"people are yearning to break the shackles and speak their truth."

"it encourages individuality...there's no need for an echo chamber."

"i like that it's centered around topics and things that matter rather than a sea of content."

"i love cyph because I can find actual scholars whom i would want to talk with."

"humanity needs a platform that tells them to go outside."

"the internet was built to enable resource sharing and open communication, not to suppress them."

"the world needs an ed-tech platform built by someone who knows how to resonate with culture."

"this feels like a breath of fresh air. online today is extremely gimmicky."

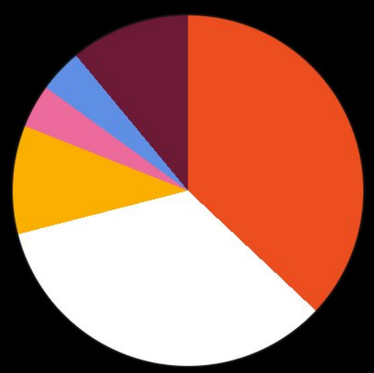
the raise.

$1.25M
raising

$11.25M
pre-money cap

15 mo
runway

use of funds



37% ops team

3 FTEs: Jalen Daniels, Activation Lead, Library Scientist

Activation Lead events, social media

Library Scientist archival oversight, curation

34% eng team

2 FTEs: Bryan Cash, Creative Technologist, SWE Contract Fund

Creative Technologist principal engineer, specializing in video game design.

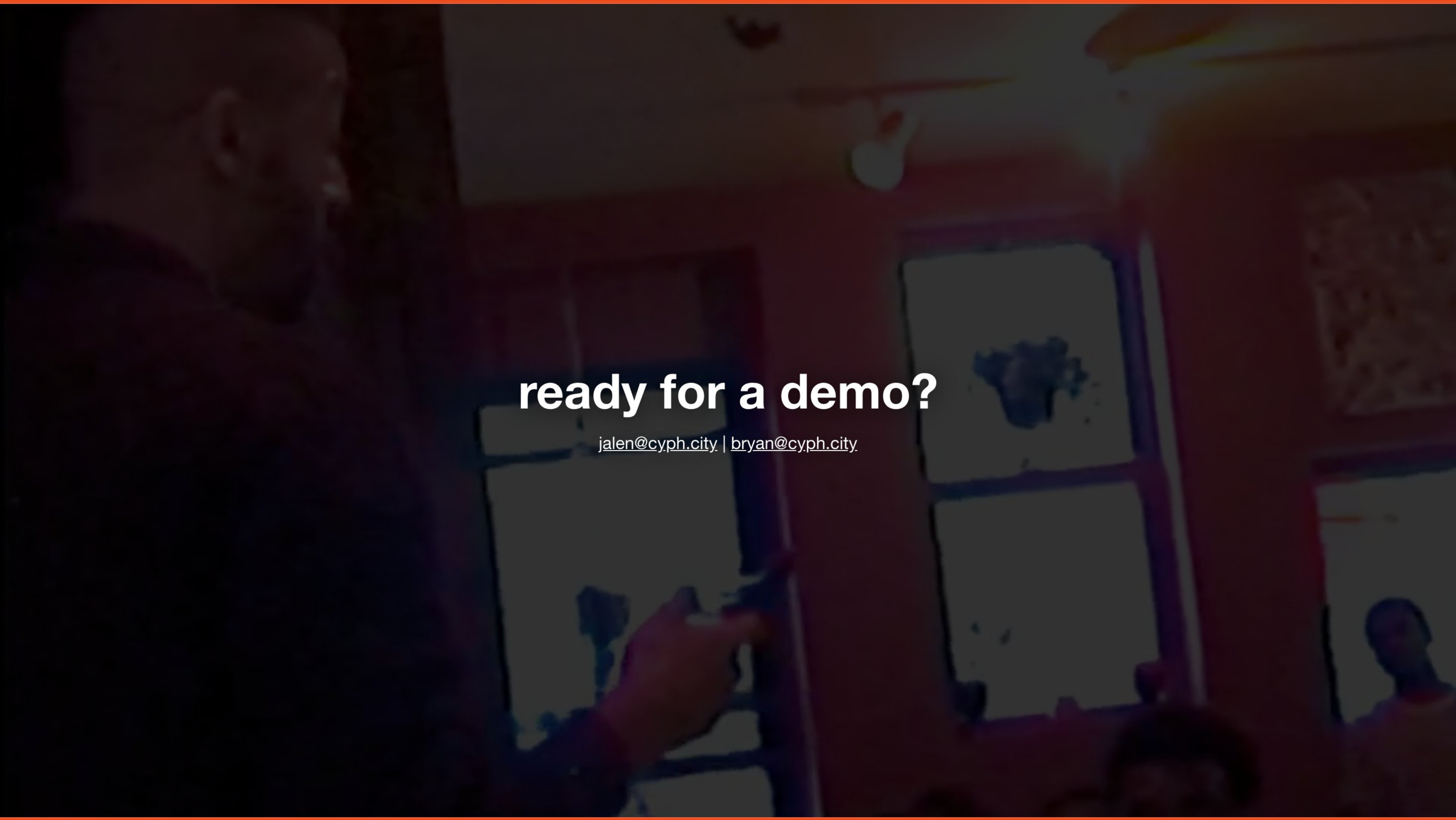
10% marketing & IRL

4% overhead

4% tech infra

11% contingency

detailed model available upon request.



ready for a demo?

jalen@cyph.city | bryan@cyph.city

why us



jalen daniels

I'm a native New Yorker and former classical ballerina. I trained for 14+ years and have performed everywhere from the Apollo Theater to the Supreme Court and the White House. At Harvard, I honed my intellectual edge through a dual honors concentration in Social Studies and African American Studies. My summa award-winning thesis, "Enemies of The New: Transhumanism, Blackness, and Fleshless Imaginaries," intervenes in the evolving conversation on race, humanity, and technology and is now moving toward publication.

After college, I worked at McKinsey & Co., focusing on entertainment, Web3/Crypto, and economic mobility; I ended my time working on the Firm's first documentary film that premiered at Martha's Vineyard Film Festival. I then served as Chief of Staff at an art and technology startup, which had partnerships with Sotheby's, OpenAI, the Brooklyn Museum, Spotify, and more.

Today, my work sits at the intersection of culture, ideas, and institutional imagination. I serve as the youngest Trustee in the history of the Harvard Club of New York City, where I focus on revitalizing innovation and bringing world-class speakers with provoking ideas. I am grateful to be the Strategic Lead of an emerging private school in Houston ($65M raise) with a rich curriculum in Black Diasporic identity and theology. I have advised copious Fortune 500 companies, and I am a consultant on some of the most exciting brands, including some stealth startups started by ex TIME and GQ executives. In my free time, I host public speaking engagements on technology, theology, and philosophy.

why us



bryan cash

I'm a born-and-raised New Yorker and lifelong sports junkie—a kid from Jamaica, Queens who was obsessed with box scores, improbable correlations, and the energy of people. I've always seen the world through data long before it was a buzzword. I was the kid fascinated by how fast the NBA could aggregate Dwyane Wade's performance based on Gabrielle Union's attendance. That curiosity is what led me to study Computer Science at Syracuse. I wanted to help businesses uncover deep analytics that unlock real storytelling.

My career has always lived at the intersection of data and real-world impact. I audited multi-billion-dollar settlements, including the Volkswagen emissions scandal; rebuilt the analytics backbone for The Washington Post's Publishing & Circulation team; and helped scale Vantage Risk's Political, Risk & Credit unit from $70M to over $225M in Gross Written Premium (GWP), contributing to the firm surpassing $1B+ GWP. While compelled by the power of data across these experiences, I wanted to bring my technology journey full circle and build platforms with cultural resonance.

I created my own sports analytics company, delivering proprietary data you couldn't find anywhere else. I then became CTO of an art and technology startup, which had partnerships with major institutions such as Sotheby's, Spotify, OpenAI, the Brooklyn Museum, and more.

Today, my work blends engineering rigor with cultural intuition, and is always driven by the belief that technology should amplify our humanity, not replace it. That's why we started Cyph.